

▲ GURMEET SINGH MEET HAYER, *35*

| AAP | *Sangrur, Punjab*

With no family background in politics, 'Meet', as his friends call him, met his métier in the inner circle of CM Bhagwant Mann—entrusted with five ministries. As it happened, he was the only one among five ministers who contested and won. That too against the tide, wresting Sangrur back for AAP—Mann had won it twice before grizzled radical icon Simranjit Singh Mann's 2022 bypoll victory presaged a turn in Punjab politics. This son of a sub-divisional officer, who had joined India Against Corruption and become an AAP founder-member, exemplifies the party's promise of bringing a common touch to high office.



▲ KISHORI LAL SHARMA, *63*

| CONGRESS | *Amethi, UP*

The prodigal son never returned. Instead, the electorate got Option B—the unpretentious point person in Rae Bareli and Amethi for all matters linked to the Gandhi family. The challenge was met with more derision than anticipation. In the end, Sharma, whose two daughters also went around on the campaign trail saying how they had grown up seeing their father devote his life to Amethi, managed to trim the aggrandised stature of Modi cabinet fixture Smriti Irani, who till then had been claiming Rahul Gandhi had fled a contest.

SHAFI PARAMBIL, *41* ▶

| CONGRESS | *Vadakara, Kerala*



The state Youth Congress chief whose winsome smile and oratory have won him a huge fan base is turning out to be another habitual giant-slayer. Palakkad MLA thrice in a row, the third stint was won—in 2021—by cocking a snook at the BJP's 'alternative chief minister', Metro Man E. Sreedharan, who was so sure of winning that he had opened an office in town and taken a house on rent. This time, he's gone up a notch, pulling one over none other than K.K. Shailaja Teacher, Kerala's talismanic Covid warrior and, in some eyes, future CM material, in a superheated contest.



◀ LUMBA RAM CHOUDHARY, *59*

| BJP | *Jalore-Sirohi, Rajasthan*

On one side was a 44-year-old dynast, Vaibhav Gehlot, who hadn't yet shown much signs of being a wunderkind in politics, having already lost a Lok Sabha election. But Papa Gehlot, having lost his CM's chair, was treating the rest of the 2024 election as background noise—only Jalore mattered. But a Class 10-pass farmer, risen from the Sirohi panchayat to be the BJP's district chief, proved his party was right to see winnability in him. His years of grassroot work paid off in a constituency whose cumin fields, in the shadow of Mt Abu, are watered by the Narmada canal.



▲ SUDAMA PRASAD, *63*

| CPI(ML) | *Arrah, Bihar*

The man with an apt name for proletarian blessings was almost written off before the first vote was cast. In the end, no one would grudge him a visit to his family small sweet shop: he had stopped the rath of Union minister and ex-home secretary R.K. Singh. And regained Arrah for his 'left-of-left' cohort after 35 years. In his debut contest in 1990, he had failed to replicate what his comrades had pulled off a year before. He made amends twice, first in 2015—right after he led a farmer's movement in Bhojpur—and then in 2020. Now the Sudamas of Arrah have made amends.